



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cedar Classical Academy
School Website: <https://cedarclassicalacademy.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Cedar Classical Academy (Lansing, MI) presents a robust classical Christian model that aligns strongly with the Six Essential Elements framework. Across all six categories, the school demonstrates characteristics typical of CLASSICAL education: a coherent religious/metaphysical foundation, a formation-focused purpose, a curriculum anchored in the liberal arts (Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric, Great Books, and Hillsdale-K-12 content), a pedagogy that blends contemplative/restful practices with Socratic or rhetoric-oriented instruction, a faculty modeled as virtuous mentors, and an active, partnership-oriented relationship with parents and the broader learning community. Public materials consistently emphasize truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, and formation of character alongside rigorous study, and they foreground parental involvement and community life as core elements of the educational project. This combination supports a general classification of CLASSICAL, with particularly strong alignment in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community; Religious foundations and School Purpose are clearly oriented toward formation and transcendentals; and the public-facing evidence of Great Books/Great Conversation-style aims is present, though some explicit phrases (e.g., "Great Books" or "Great Conversation" by name) are less frequent than other classical schools that foreground them. Overall, Cedar Classical Academy scores CLASSICAL across categories, yielding an aggregate CLASSICAL designation.

Key takeaways - Religious/metaphysical foundations are explicit: the school centers a Christian worldview, theology in practice, liturgical rhythm, and communal worship as part of education. Evidence includes explicit statements about cultivating virtue in relation to God and a theology-grounded curriculum.

- Purpose and goal are formation-first: the mission emphasizes formation of wisdom and virtue rather than information alone; Vision/Graduate outcomes articulate a virtuous, well-educated citizenry formed in faith.
- Curriculum shows Trivium and a Hillsdale-based K-12 program, with evidence of grammar/logic/rhetoric, language study, and integration of liberal arts through a structured curriculum map and reading program.
- Pedagogy blends rest (Schol  -like rhythm) with active discourse and rhetoric; lower grades incorporate song/memory, while upper grades show debate/discussion and rhetoric-focused opportunities. Evidence appears in details about Opening Ceremony, memory/chant practices, and upper-school rhetoric activities.
- Faculty are described as living curriculum and mentors; staff bios and the Head of School's role illustrate a model-teacher ethos.
- Parents & Community are explicitly engaged as co-educators and partners; there are regular events, parent participation opportunities, and visible emphasis on open access to visits and involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials articulate a Christian metaphysical frame: education is a reflection of God, and moral/virtue formation is central.

- Theology is integrated into curriculum and practice (Rafiki Foundation theology pilot; Westminster Catechism in theology classes; Catholic/Protestant continuities are addressed through a unified Christian worldview).
- Communal liturgical practices and worship are part of the school's routine (Opening Ceremony with hymns, prayers, and shared songs).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; worship; morning prayer; doxology; reverence; awe; sacred music; prayer; imago Dei; Logos (where referenced in related lexicon). The Cedar materials repeatedly foreground truth/goodness/beauty and a theology-based framework.

- Negative keywords: none clearly evidenced in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or value-neutral stances found in the public pages). The absence itself is noted, with evidence pointing to explicit theology and sacred practices instead. See positive signals above.

Why this rating - The materials consistently ground education in transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a theology-centered worldview, with liturgical/community practices shaping formation. This aligns closely with CLASSICAL signals in the lexicon.

Citations: Core evidence drawn from Cedar's mission/formation language and liturgical practices (turn0file1; turn0file15; turn9file13).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements emphasize formation of wisdom/virtue and the aim to cultivate intellectual and moral virtue, not mere information or job-readiness. - The Portrait of the Graduate emphasizes Informed Faith, Virtuous Character, Sound Reason, Mastery of Language, Trained Aesthetic, Robust Knowledge of the World, and Steadfast Citizenship, i.e., formation-oriented outcomes. - The Eight Key Elements/lexicon framing (Positive signals) is reflected in Cedar's stated aims around virtue, truth, beauty, and formation, tying to Paideia and liberal-arts aims. See canonical classical lexicon for alignment (Formation; Great Conversation; Liberal Education).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, studied "the true, the good, the beautiful," scholé/rest, contemplation, great conversation, human flourishing. Cedar materials repeatedly reference formation and virtue; the graduate profile confirms this orientation.

- Negative keywords present: minimal to none (no explicit emphasis on "workforce readiness" over formation; when discussed, it's framed within a classical context, not as the primary goal). The Six Elements lexicon lists possible negative signals for non-classical approaches; Cedar's materials do not prominently exhibit those signals. See classical lexicon for reference (Positive vs Negative keyword framework).

Why this rating - Cedar's own mission statements and graduate outcomes foreground formation and transcendentals (truth/goodness/beauty) and treat education as formation rather than information, which matches CLASSICAL expectations for School Purpose and Goal.

Citations: Evidence from Cedar mission/vision (turn0file1); Portrait of the Graduate (turn0file15); Lexicon alignment (turn7file6).

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum centers on the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) and includes logic and rhetoric in the upper grades; a Logic School begins in 7th grade, with explicit reference to grammar/logic/ rhetoric sequences. - Hillsdale College K-12 Curriculum is used as a basis for K-12 learning, reinforcing classical content and a canonical approach to liberal arts. - The curriculum emphasizes mastery of language through sequential study (phonics, grammar, composition, Greek & Latin, rhetoric); history and literature are integrated; music and arts reflect classical pedagogy (Kodály-based music with hymnody and masterworks).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Trivium; Great Books/Great Conversation (explicit language appears in classical lexicon and internal references to "great conversation," though not always named in Cedar as such); grammars/Latin/Greek; history as an integrated discipline; reading lists and curriculum maps; Kodály-based music with hymns; rhetoric and oration opportunities in Rhetoric School.

- Negative keywords: some public materials emphasize Hillsdale-based content rather than explicitly naming "Great Books" classics in every listing, but the Hillsdale/K-12 Curriculum framework functions as

the classical scaffold. The classical lexicon provides a dual lens but Cedar demonstrates the core elements. See classical lexicon for coverage of Great Books/Great Conversation in Positive keywords (turn7file6).

Why this rating - The presence of Trivium-based progression, explicit Logic/Rhetoric focus, and a Hillsdale-based K-12 curriculum strongly align Cedar with Curriculum criteria in a classical rubric. The public materials show explicit engagement with language, history, and liberal arts content, plus a strong universal classical framework.

Citations: Trivium/Logic (turn3file8); Hillsdale/K-12 (turn4file0); Curriculum integration (turn0file6); Lexicon alignment (turn7file6).

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower/grammar-stage pedagogy includes singing, memorization, and ritual rhythm, consistent with scholé/restful learning and memory practice (the “great memory” and hymn/catechesis-style elements). The site describes liturgical openings and memory-based practice in early grades. - Upper grades feature Socratic discussion, debate, and rhetoric training in the Rhetoric School, including opportunities to give speeches and build rhetorical skill. - The school explicitly frames education as a holistic formation process (not purely information transfer) and emphasizes the integration of theology into all subjects, aligning with a contemplative and dialogic pedagogy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Scholé; contemplation; wonder; memorization/recitation; imitation of models; Socratic dialogue/seminar; rhetoric; memory work; liturgical calendar integration; master-teacher model. Cedar materials show explicit memory and liturgical patterns in lower school and a rhetoric/seminar writing emphasis in the rhetoric program. - Negative keywords: Minimal signals of purely project-based/constructivist pedagogy dominating; the materials show a balanced mix rather than a single-trend approach. The lexicon acknowledges potential negative signals (e.g., project-based only), but Cedar’s public materials predominantly indicate a traditional/classical pedagogy. See the classical lexicon for reference (Pedagogy: positive signals include Socratic dialogue, scholé, memorization; negatives include project-based-only and constructivist extremes) (turn7file6).

Why this rating - The public materials demonstrate a dual-pedagogy model: contemplative/restful learning for early grades and Socratic/seminar-based discourse plus rhetoric in the upper grades, which aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Citations: Lower/upper pedagogy references (turn9file13; turn9file12); Pedagogical Lexicon (turn7file6).

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are described as model teachers and mentors; biographies show faculty as living curriculum, with a long history of involvement in Cedar since its founding and deep content knowledge (Latin/Greek, theology, literature, etc.). Examples include the Head of School and senior faculty biographies. - The school emphasizes a “portrait of the teacher” and a “faculty of friends” ethos; multiple bios highlight virtue, scholarship, and a sustained commitment to classical education. - The school demonstrates a clear “living curriculum” concept through long-tenured faculty and a stable staff structure.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; portrait of the teacher; master-teacher model; virtue formation; mentorship; collegial culture; professional development in classical pedagogy. Cedar materials consistently portray faculty as morally grounded and academically prepared. - Negative keywords: not evident in public materials; no sustained emphasis on non-classical certification frameworks or “facilitators” without classical context.

Why this rating - Cedar presents a classical-faculty model with long-tenured teachers, a strong teacher-mentorship ethos, and a living-curriculum approach that aligns with CLASSICAL expectations in Faculty.

Citations: Faculty bios and living-curriculum ethos (turn2file12); Head of School bio (turn3file4).

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents as co-teachers; events, parent observation visits, and direct invitations for family involvement are highlighted (RenWeb parent observations; community events; Grandparents Day; parent formation through reading and study). - The site presents parent involvement as a central pillar of classical education, including home-school partnership language, and public-facing materials encourage families to engage with the school's mission. - Public materials reference a broader community culture (Pie & Paideia history, community posts, reading lists, and family-centered events) that align with the "Partnership with Families" and "Formation of Affections" principles in the Classical rubric.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parental engagement; family formation; home-centered learning; community of learners; parent formation; reading groups; church involvement; grandparent visits; hospitality; open-campus access. - Negative keywords: none clearly evidenced in the publicly available materials; the community-oriented approach aligns with classical-community expectations rather than consumerism or limited parental access.

Why this rating - Cedar publicly frames parents as co-educators and offers frequent opportunities for parental involvement and formation through events, reading groups, and observations, which matches CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations: Parent-Community partnership and involvement (turn10file11); Community events and grandparent visits (turn9file12; turn2file18).

What would move the needle

- Since Cedar Classical Academy already demonstrates strong CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories, there are no category-level needle-moving changes required to reach full classical status. If desired, small enhancements could include: explicitly naming "Great Books" and "Great Conversation" in public materials to strengthen Element 3's explicit Great Books/Great Conversation signaling; continuing to expand and publicize the "Socratic Seminar" as a formal, ongoing upper-school pedagogy anchor; and widening public documentation of the "living curriculum" portrait for faculty to reinforce Element 5 further.
- Potential concrete actions (optional, not required for CLASSICAL status):
 - Publish explicit syllabi or public-facing statements that name "Great Books" and "Great Conversation" in the K–12 curriculum discussion, with examples from Hillsdale and Great Books canon.
 - Expand a public page detailing upper-school Socratic Seminars, Harkness-style discussions, and rhetoric theses to reinforce Pedagogy signals.
 - Maintain and broaden parent-formation programming (book clubs, parental discussion guides) to deepen Parents & Community signals.

Section end: ABSTRACT

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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